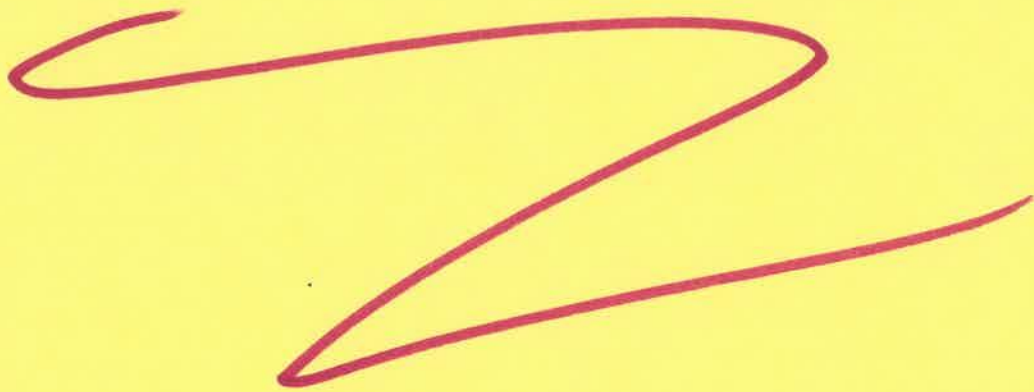


RADICAL LOVE



PAID IN FULL

PAID IN FULL

PAID IN FULL

Radical In-to-me-see

Radical intimacy is the direct result of sharing everything about yourself that is unspeakable, with another person or people, and being willing to experience the next moment, whatever it brings. There is nothing between you and someone else at that moment. You don't need to agree with, or feel good about your partner at any given time

This willingness to transcend your fears and conditioning and stay in relationship is an endless gift. How we relate to someone we love provides an extremely clear and accurate mirror of how we relate to ourselves. For this reason, relationships help us face and understand ourselves more rapidly and profoundly than any other aspect of worldly life.

The Choice of Love



What does the voice of fear
whisper to you?

Fear speaks to you
in logic and reason.

Loving truth says,
"Only give me
this moment."

Fear would walk you
on a narrow path
promising to take you
where you want to go.

Love says,
"Open your arms
and fly with me."

Every moment of your life
You are offered the opportunity

To choose-
Love or fear,
It assumes the language
of love itself.

Fear tells you,
"I want to make you safe."
Love says, "You are safe."

Fear says,
"Give me symbols.
Give me frozen images.
Give me something
I can rely on."

To tread the earth
Or to soar the heavens?

Week One - Context

Introduction

The Art & Science of Mindful Living is not a temporary fix. This is the real thing. It probably won't fit your pictures. But, attempting to fit our pictures is what continues a paralytic treadmill of trying and using techniques and reminders to achieve the life we desire while still operating from our conditioning. Of course, nothing occurs in a vacuum except sweeping up the dirt available and emptying it out each time we sweep.

This program promises the ultimate disruptive support for choosing to see clearly and be in integrity with our natural self.

What are your deepest desires in this program?

What are your fears in this program?

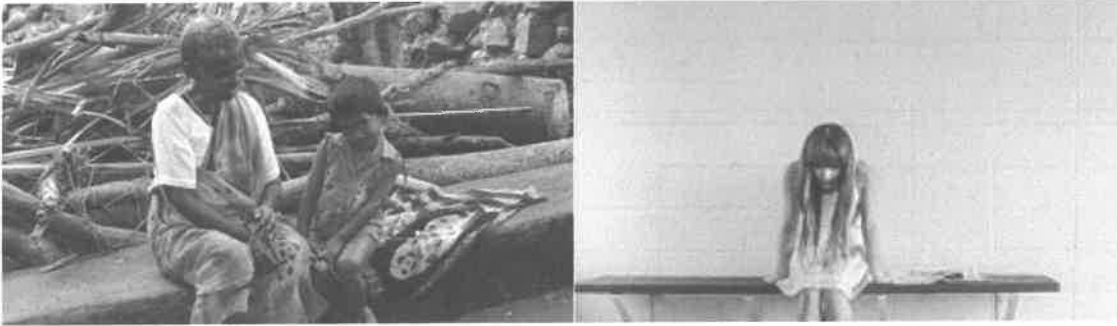
Who are we? What are we?
Do we think people can really hurt our feelings?

Context of Love

Context of Fear

[illegible]

Context vs. Content



Words are only 10% [at best] of a communication. The rest is context.

Children do not hear words; they hear what is behind the words.

So does everybody else.

Role Play:

Imagine a parent saying: "What are you doing?" to a child from a place of:

- Fondness
- Rage
- Suspicion
- Concern

Imagine a person saying: "I feel crazy" to their lover from a place of:

- Blaming it on the other
- Frantic to be understood
- Wanting to share something intimate

Now imagine yourself saying: "Thank you for sharing" from a place of:

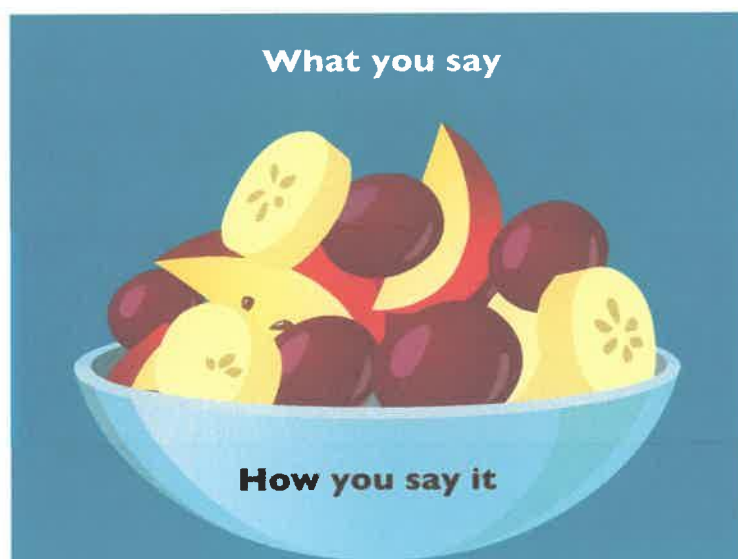
- Terrified to confront anything and wanting to shut someone up
- Judgment of the speaker
- Sarcasm
- Appreciation for what was shared

You get the picture?

Recipe for Setting Context with Mindful Living

(Follow exactly—no substitutions)

1. Have a vision, be your vision.
2. Be real /authentic.
3. Come from the big picture of what needs to happen for the benefit of all.
4. Say exactly what you mean with nothing added or left out.
5. Allow discomfort even though you may feel intimidated or try to make others feel better.
6. Treat everyone as equal beings, including children.
7. Assume that what everyone has to say has value.
8. Ask questions rather than “telling.” Allow discovery
9. Go to the biggest possible picture of what they say.
10. Share your passion about what is important to you.



Do Yourself a F.A.V.O.R.

(*or experiencing value with everyone)

The F.A.V.O.R Method

F - Feel

Know what you are feeling. This is a clue to what the other person is feeling and how you are responding. Put yourself in their place. Recognize in yourself the emotion that is the source of what the other person is saying. Notice any judgments.

A - Acknowledge

Acknowledge the emotion through direct recognition. If not possible, do it in a non-threatening way by exaggeration or humor. Ask a question to clarify the real statement, to confirm that you have received the same emotion that has been sent.

V - Validate

Validate the statement and the other person. This does not mean you have to agree with them. You are letting them know that you've heard them and understand their concern. Remember, if you were that person with their life experiences and their thoughts and feelings, you would respond exactly as they do.

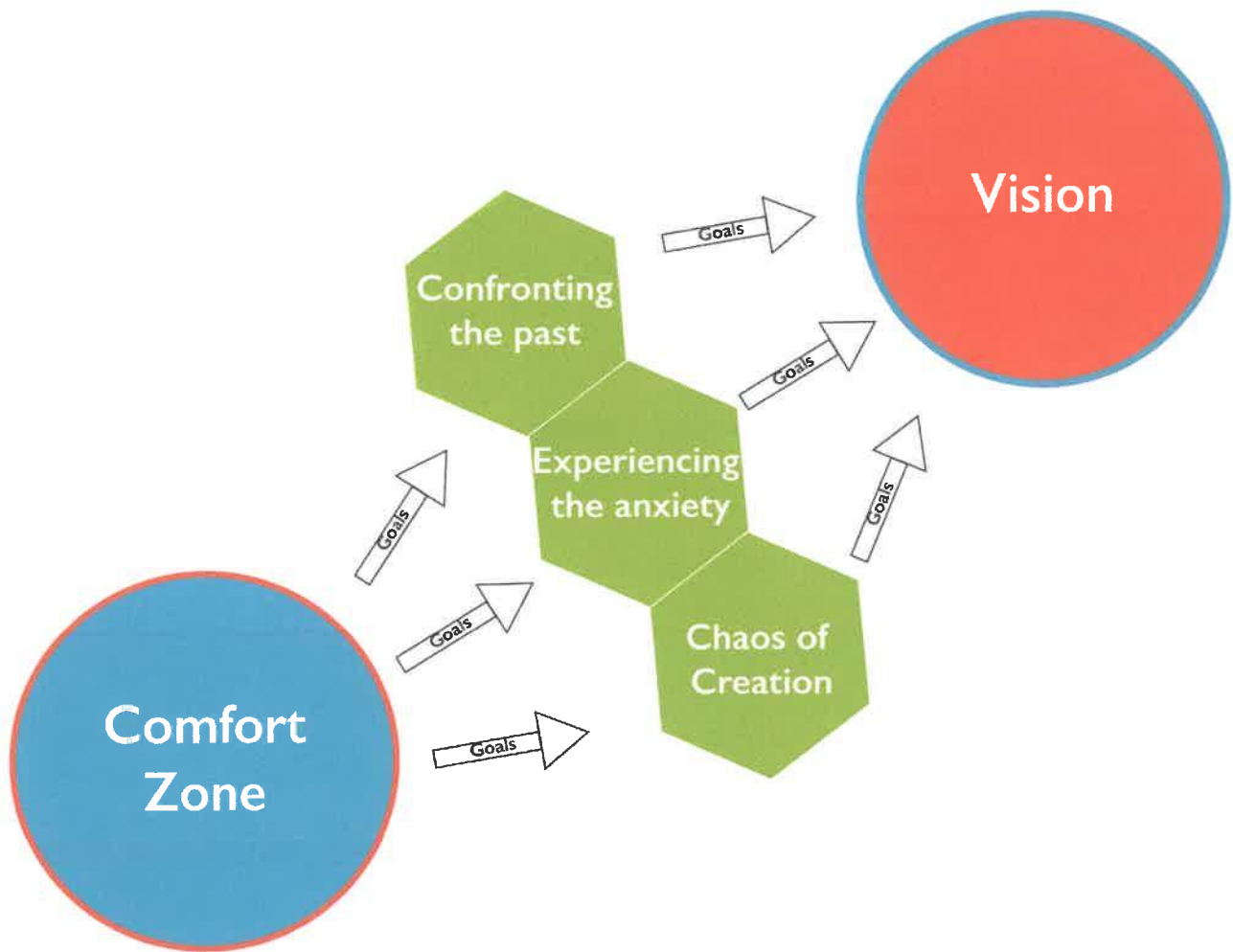
O - Open

Open the space by including yourself in what the other person is describing. "I've felt that way myself." Or share what arises for you. By doing this, you are giving the other person time to realize that he or she is not alone. You are giving yourself the opportunity to connect with yourself and the other person.

R - Return

Return to the original situation. Complete what was started. Relate to your experience, knowledge, or expertise, if applicable. Then let the other person discover the answer to his or her own dilemma.

Leaving the Comfort Zone



Mindful Goal Setting

- Waking up is essential for mindful goal-setting.
- Mindful goal setting requires letting go of your past.
- Sustainable change is impossible without paradox.
- Paradox is a pain in the ass.
- All emotions are equal and essential for achieving goals.
- This entails leaving your comfort zone.

Cognitive Dissonance

Doing everything in the bullet points above is not an easy task. It requires looking deeply at one's self and standing strong in the face of our own limiting beliefs while maintaining a willingness to change. To do this we need to be disrupted, our thoughts and behaviors need to be shaken up. We call this cognitive dissonance. No one likes this experience in the moment.

When cognitive dissonance affects an individual, the brain goes into overload. Old beliefs get shaken. That which was taken as truth is now challenged and called into doubt. In order to learn and take in new information, the brain is agitated in this way. When experiencing cognitive dissonance, we cannot think our way to accept new information, even if it makes sense intellectually. New truths necessitate new behaviors.

COMMITMENT

Until one is committed

there is hesitancy, the chance to draw back,
always ineffectiveness.

Concerning all acts of initiative (and creation)

there is one elementary truth,

the ignorance of which kills countless ideas
and splendid plans:

that the moment one definitely commits oneself,
then Providence moves too.

All sorts of things occur to help one

that would otherwise never have occurred.

A whole stream of events issues from the decision,

raising in one's favor all manner

of unforeseen incidents and meetings

and material assistance

which no man could have dreamt

would have come his way.

I have learned a deep respect

for one of Goethe's couplets:

***“Whatever you can do, or dream you can...begin it. Boldness has genius,
power and magic in it.”***

W.N. Murray, The Scottish Himalayan Expedition, 1951



Wake Up, your life is waiting!!

Self-Assessment of My Progress

My goals for this program are:

The aspects of my past that stand in my way are:

To achieve my goals I will have to feel:

The behaviors essential to achieve my goals are:

What % committed am I at this very moment?



My Story, or Why I am the Way I am

Interim Assignment:

1. Pick a partner.

2. Share your story with your partner. Your partner can interrupt at any point to tell how they are experiencing you and suggest another way to tell it. Notice your response to this each time you are interrupted.

You each do this until you both can make the distinction between feeling fear and being fear. And between feeling love and being love.

3. Practice setting context in relationship, at work, with everyone you meet, all week.

*What do you know
about life?*

Week 2 - Insight

Insight is the result of knowing ourselves. Once we know how we got to where we are, we can use that knowledge to illuminate the future rather than continue to undermine ourselves in the present. Under our beliefs is seeing ourselves in pure awareness, just costumed as points of view.

**Who do we really think we are?
Do we think people don't see us?**

We all have something in us that burns. Insight is the result of sitting in the fire with others to witness the burning.



"Understanding is the booby-prize." –Werner Erhard

Emotions

We know from quantum physics that emotions are simply waves of energy. Sometimes, the wave passes through us as if we are transparent, other times, they stick to us and we react to them and attract the same emotion over and over again. They stick to us until we make certain distinctions about others and ourselves.

Emotions are pure energy and exist both inside and outside of us simultaneously. When an external stimulus occurs that resonates with an emotional state inside of us, we respond based on how well we know ourselves.

What happens to those emotions? Do they stay inside us? All emotions eventually move through us as long as we are willing to experience them fully. When we do not, we wall this un experienced anxiety.

The table below gives some examples of common patterns – from sensations to feelings (interpreted sensation), judgments and reactions. See whether any of the patterns feel familiar to you.

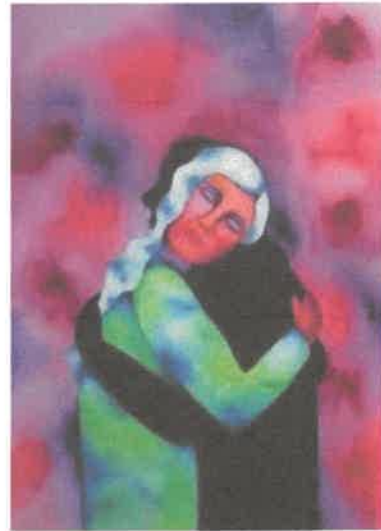
Sensation	Feeling	Judgement	Reaction
Burning	Anger	Not Okay	Blame
Pressure	Fear	Not Okay	Numb/Hysteria
Warmth	Love	Not Okay	Caution/Sexual Pleasure
Emptiness	Needy	Not Okay	Isolation/Bingeing
Full	Happy	Not Okay	Fat/Not Eating
Tingling	Excitement	Okay	No Reaction
Tingling	Turned On	Not Okay	Fighting

There are many events in our past that we want to leave behind, so we cloud them up or create pleasant illusions to cover the pain. When we do this our conscious minds forget what really happened. The effects of these experiences don't disappear. The particles of experience build up and begin to control our behavior, albeit unconsciously. We have extraordinary resistance to opening ourselves to experience the core experience we have been protecting.

The Shadow Knows!



All emotions are equal.
In many ancient healing systems,
emotions are experienced like organs.



Those emotions that we consider
negative are the doorway to freedom,
just like resistance is.



Reflect on your childhood:



1. What feelings were unacceptable in your family?
2. How did you feel you had to behave with your mother?
3. How did you feel you had to behave with your father?
4. Do you feel you have to behave in those ways with anyone in a present relationship?
5. Does anyone in a present relationship have to behave that way with you?
6. What was your father's childhood like?
7. What was your mother's childhood like?

True Desire

You discover you only have a short time to live. What do you want to experience? Who do you want to speak to and what do you want to say?

What is stopping you from living like this now?

How do you want to be remembered?



*Insight is the
preparation for
Personal Responsibility.*

*Who Are You?
What are you made of?*

*Take moments each day
and sit quietly*

Notice life around you

*Sweep the debris
from your mind*



*Reveal paradoxes
in your life.*

*Watch how they
dance in your mind.*



Self-Assessment of My Progress

My Goals for this Program are:

The aspects of my past that stand in my way are:

To achieve my goals I will have to feel:

The behaviors essential to achieve my goals are:

What % committed am I at this very moment?

Interim Assignment:

Use the DeepSee app. Do six days on the first Principle - Insight, and share your journey each day with your partner.

As your partner speaks, share your experience of them.

You will each find out about yourself by watching all the arguments, stories, and explanations that come up in your mind and receiving what your partner's experience of you is.



Personal Journal

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal blue or grey lines across its entire width. The lines are thin and consistent in color, providing a guide for handwriting. There is no text, margin, or other markings on the page.



Personal Journal

[illegible]

Week 3 - Personal Responsibility

Owning Yourself

Knowing that we are the source and authority of our experience, and recognizing how we create our results – tangible and intangible.

**Who do we really think we are?
Do we think people can make us be
something we are not?**

Exercise:

What outcome or event in your life do you have the biggest resistance to seeing yourself responsible for? Please write down what arises.

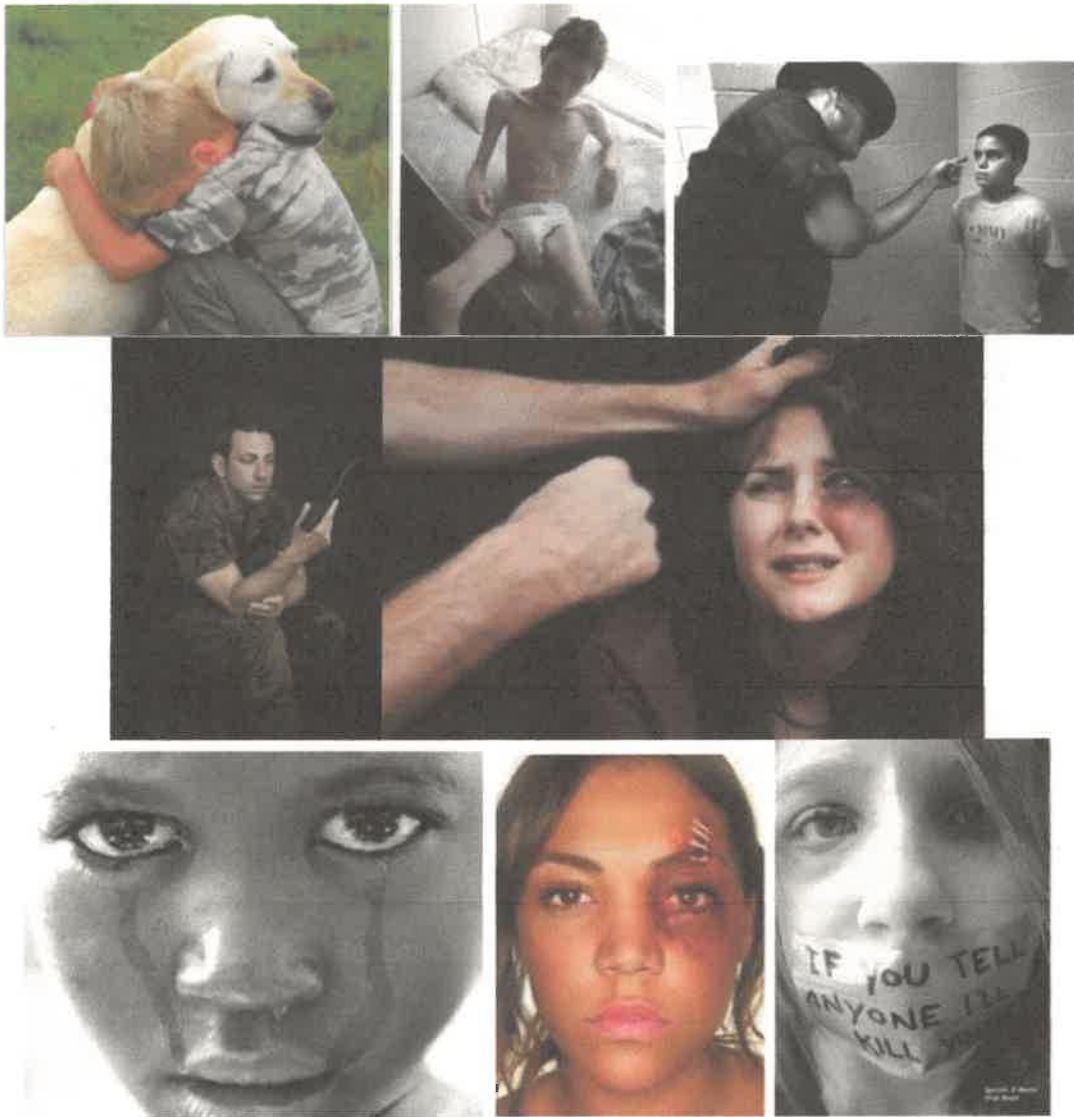


Telling people what they want to hear is a form of dishonesty.

Not saying all that arises to “protect” someone is a form of dishonesty.

Adding a positive or negative spin when sharing is a form of dishonesty.

Take a look at these pictures and reflect on what you feel and think:



Please write down whatever comes up when you look at those pictures, then share with a partner in class:

Take a look at this picture and reflect on what you feel and think:



Please write down whatever comes up when you look at this picture, then share with your partner in class:

What are your beliefs about your body? Stand naked in front of a mirror and notice what you think and feel about your body. Share with your partner in class.

Judge 'Til You Drop



For the next few days, notice your judgments of yourself and others. As you see patterns, we ask you to write them down. After you've noticed your judgments and patterns, then ask yourself

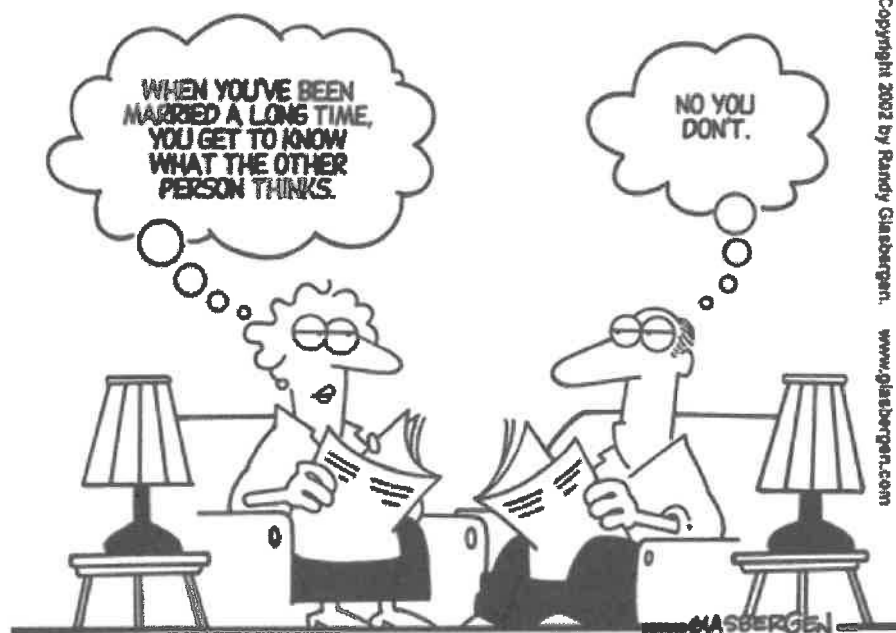
- 1) How do I feel when I judge?
- 2) How do I feel when I am judged?
- 3) How am I like that which I'm judging?
- 4) Imagine life without these judgments.

Judgment always presents itself through a veil of separation. Whether we are judging others or ourselves, and whether we are aware or not, we are engaging in self-abuse.

Check it out!

Projection = Giving Away Our Power

One of the biggest blocks to happiness is a habit everyone learns as a child. It is so ingrained that most of us think it is a natural part of who we are. However, it is not intrinsic to our nature, but learned. It saps us of our power as surely as Kryptonite turned Superman into a weakling. It happens when people do not approve of their feelings and fool themselves into believing the feelings are coming from someone else. This phenomenon is known as “projection.” The problem with projecting is that we see ourselves as victims of someone else’s actions rather than being the author of our own experience. Seeing ourselves as being responsible for our own experience is being truly free.



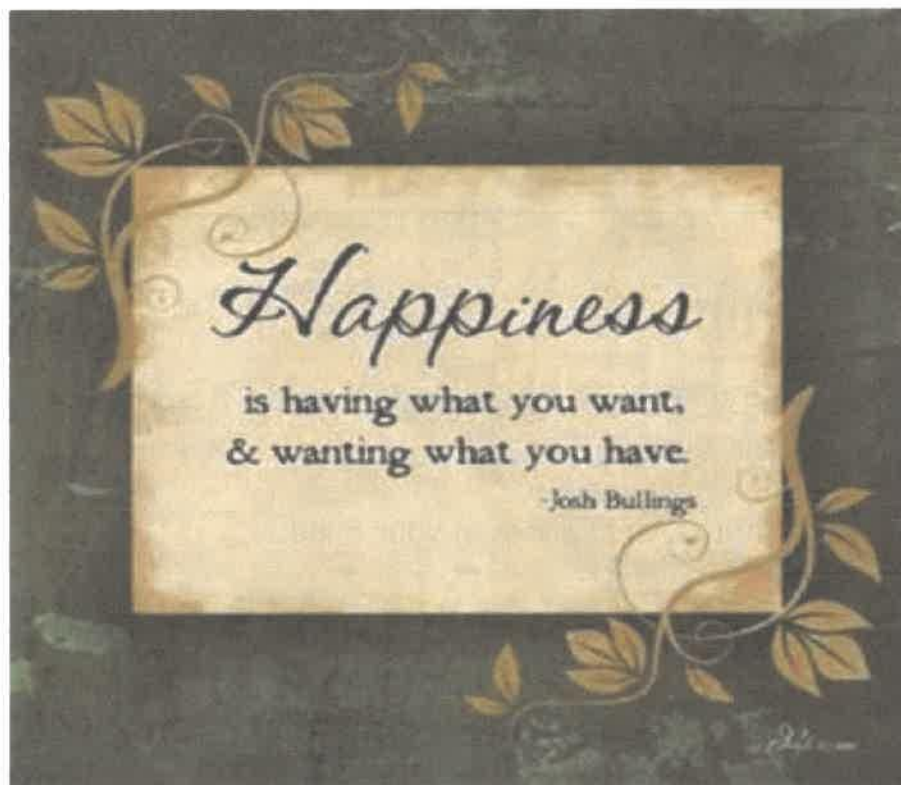
A simple meditation:

Sit quietly for 5 minutes each day. During that time, as your thoughts move, watch them come and go.

Bring to mind those people to whom you have begrudged your love or judged.

How have they have contributed to your life.

Notice how you can hold this paradox.



Self-Assessment of My Progress

My Goals for this Program are:

The aspects of my past that stand in my way are:

To achieve my goals I will have to feel:

The behaviors essential to achieve my goals are:

Interim Assignment:

Use the DeepSee app. Do six days on the second Principle- Responsibility and share your journey each day with your partner.

As your partner speaks, notice what arises in your mind.

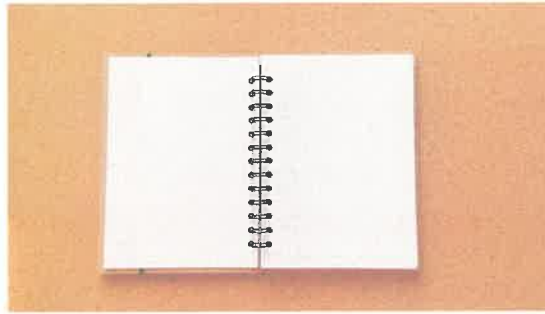
Share the content of your mind with your partner.

Continue to examine the question, who am I? By now, you probably have an inkling of the truth of who you are.



Personal Journal

[illegible]



Personal Journal

[illegible]

Week 4 - Personal Responsibility Towards Others

Making amends for blame and judgment by dissolving 'right vs wrong', 'better vs worse' thinking in favor of a more balanced view and assuming that others have a positive intent. Healing damaged relationships.

Who do we really think we are?

Are we separate from other people?

Reflect on these questions:

Who have you cheated?

Who have you abandoned?

Who have you gossiped about?

Who have you blamed?

Who have you neglected?

Who have you abused?

How have you cheated yourself?

How have you abandoned yourself?

How have you belittled yourself?

What do you blame yourself for?

How do you neglect yourself?

How have you abused yourself?

Who have you lied to?

What lies do you tell yourself?

Who have you led astray?

How have you led yourself astray?

Who have you betrayed?

How have you betrayed yourself?

Who have you made promises to that you have not kept?

What promises have you broken to yourself?

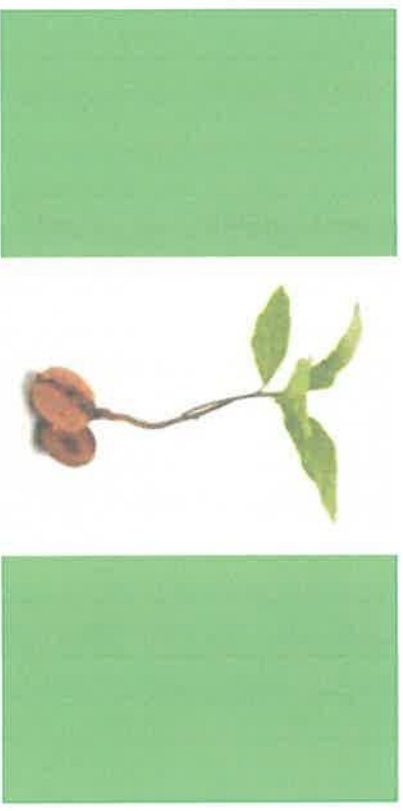
**Not doing something and saying that
you did is meant to be dishonest.**

**Preferring to look like you accomplished
something over actually doing it is dis-
honest.**

**Do you want the consequences of being
dishonest? Why not just tell the truth?**

**Right action to Reconnect Your Heart with
those you love.**

- Have conversations you have avoided with those close to you. Now is a good time for repair.
- Remember a time that you blamed another for your own results.
- Find that person and discuss this with them. Let them know that you are aware of what you did.
- Look at an incident or a relationship you have not wanted to resolve or complete. Take an action in this situation. Vulnerability is pure strength.
- Since we only experience feeling lost when we have disconnected, offer your hand to create connection with someone in need, someone who might feel lost as you have.
- Accept support from another when you feel lost or need help.



Out beyond ideas of wrongdoing
and right doing, there is a field.
I'll meet you there.

When the soul lies down in that grass,
the world is too full to talk about.
Ideas, language, even the phrase each
other doesn't make any sense.

From Essential Rumi
by Coleman Barks



Keys to radical listening in relationship

- Receive what is being communicated exactly as it is, like a clear mirror
- Listen with open-hearted body-mind without personal thought or feeling.
- Receive a total transmission of all there is at that moment.
- Experience the other as ourselves. In that moment, there is no other.
- Respond to that aspect of their sharing that supports both of us and is for the benefit of all.

*This is the union of love and wisdom.
We express love in the form of presence and
connection, while also transmitting
the wisdom that
everything is complete as it is. We know that
the pain that the other person
is experiencing from
conditioned awareness isn't actually what it
seems to be.*

— Adapted from a teaching by Peter Fenner

Self-Assessment of My Progress

My Goals for this Program are:

The aspects of my past that stand in my way are:

To achieve my goals I will have to feel:

The behaviors essential to achieve my goals are:

What % committed am I at this very moment?

Interim Assignment:

Review journal entries on DeepSee app six days on the second Principle- Personal Responsibility to share with each other.

As your partner speaks, share your experience of them.

You will each find out about yourself by watching all the arguments, stories, and explanations that come up in your mind and just taking in what your partner's experience of you is.

As others speak to you this week, radically listen to and receive what they are offering.



Week 5 - Authenticity



There is a clear distinction between authentic sharing and reactive sharing. We all know when someone is pretending, although we might not know how to deal with it. It's hard-wired into our brains as a survival mechanism. Just notice how children respond to you. Although most of our families did not actively teach us this, we learned how to be by how they responded to us. We knew how to take care of their feelings. Some of us learned how not to make waves, some of us became adroit at manipulation, others blew up. We learned different ways of being, none of them right or wrong. Lots of our adaptive behaviors are a result of our unexperienced anxiety. When authentic sharing occurs, we are given nothing to think about. Why is that?

Who do we think we are?

Do we think we can be fake and people won't know?

Reactive Sharing	Authentic Sharing
<i>I don't care what you think</i>	I'm afraid to hear what you think
<i>I'm not ready to do that</i>	I don't want to do that
<i>I'm fine, you go out without me</i>	I want you to stay with me
<i>I don't understand</i>	I don't like hearing that

The Rose

by Bette Midler

Some say love, it is a river, that drowns the tender reeds

Some say love, it is a razor that leads the heart to bleed

Some say love, it is a hunger, an endless aching need

Some say love, it is a flower and you it's only seed

It's the heart, afraid of breaking that never learns to dance

It's the dream, afraid of waking that never takes the chance

It's the one who won't be taken, who cannot seem to give

And a soul, afraid of dying that never learns to live

When the night has been too lonely and the road becomes too long

And you think that love is only for the lucky and the strong

Just remember in the winter, far beneath the bitter snow lies

The seed that with the sun's love in the spring becomes the rose



Role Play Exercise- Jumping Paradigms:

1. Choose a partner
2. One person will play a homeless vet (see role card) and the other will be person walking along a bike path in Boulder.
3. The walker stops to talk to a person they meet living under a bridge by South Boulder Creek. The person living under the bridge reminds them of someone they have lost.
4. The homeless vet only shares his/her story if the walker is authentic.
5. Have a 5 minute conversation. Then switch roles.
6. One person will play a woman who has lost her children (see role card) and the other will be person walking along a bike path in Boulder.
7. The walker stops to talk to a person they meet sitting on a bench by South Boulder Creek. The sitting on the bench reminds them of someone they have lost.
8. The Woman who has lost her children only shares her story if the walker is authentic.
9. Have a 5 minute conversation.

Then share with group in debrief how the homeless vet knew if the walker was authentic, and what the experience was like for both.

Right Action for Authenticity

When you feel fear in any form, such as anger, resentment or worry, remember, your actions are always a choice. Put yourself in that gap between thought and action. Choose an action that benefits both you and others.



Self-Assessment of My Progress

My Goals for this Program are:

The aspects of my past that stand in my way are:

To achieve my goals I will have to feel:

The behaviors essential to achieve my goals are:

What % committed am I at this very moment?

Interim Assignment:

1. Use the DeepSee app. Do six days on the third Principle - Authenticity, and share your journey each day with your partner.

As your partner speaks, share your experience of them.

You will each find out about yourself by watching all the arguments, stories, and explanations that come up in your mind and just taking in what your partner's experience of you is.

2. Call a family member and infinitely listen to whatever they want to say and be authentic in your responses.



your homecoming will become my homecoming

—

*my selves go with you, only i remain;
a shadow phantom effigy or seeming*

(an almost someone always who's noone)

*a noone who, till their and your returning,
spends the forever of his loneliness
dreaming their eyes have opened to your
morning*

*feeling their stars have risen through your
skies...*

- e.e. cummings

Week 7

Lack of Integrity - Lying

It's difficult to give up believing that when you feel good, things are okay. Things are okay when you are doing what you said you'd do; when you are chaotic and still doing the behavior you chose. When there is no pretense. Sometimes it will feel good.

If you are a liar, you are a morsel for shame.

You can be knocked over by a truth teller.

It's like being blind in a world of light.

The denseness takes you over.

Lying is very addictive. It sets up a pattern that can be very difficult to break. You think that you're fooling people by lying but you're not. You're in illusion if you think people think you're telling the truth when you're lying. In a deep level, the lie comes through very strongly. The listener has to alter his/her relationship with you in some way to keep listening.

"An individual is whole and complete when their word is whole and complete, and their word is whole and complete when they honor their word," says HBS professor Michael C. Jensen. "We can honor our word in one of two ways: by keeping it on time and as promised, or if that becomes impossible, by owning up to the parties counting on us to keep our word in advance and cleaning up the mess our failure to keep our word creates in their lives."

Cleaning Up the Mess

Definition of to “lie” by Merriam Webster: to make an untrue statement with intent to deceive; to create a false or misleading impression.

Do you lie by withholding part of yourself?

Do you lie by pretending to be someone other than you are?

Do you lie by changing your speech “to keep the peace”?

Do you lie by hiding how you feel?

Do you lie to get your way?

What lies are you telling yourself?

What is the effect of a lie?

Cleaning Up the Mess

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Sounds True presents The End of Your World—An Interview with Adyashanti

More and more people are “waking up” spiritually. And for most of them, the question becomes: now what? “Information about life after awakening is usually not made public,” explains Adyashanti. “It’s most often shared only between teachers and their students.” The End of Your World is his response to a growing need for direction on the spiritual path—and his personal welcome to “a new world, a state of oneness.” In this interview conducted by Sounds True Publisher Tami Simon and excerpted from the book, Adya tells us more about the enigmatic experience of spiritual awakening.

Tami Simon: Let’s return to your metaphor of awakening being compared to a rocket ship achieving lift-off. How do people know if their rocket ship of being has actually taken off? I could imagine some people being deluded about this. Maybe they have read lots of books about spiritual awakening, so they make the leap in their mind that awakening has occurred, but perhaps in reality they are simply sputtering on the ground. How do we know for sure that we have attained liftoff?

Adyashanti: It’s not an easy question to answer. The only way I can answer it is to reiterate what the nature of awakening is.

The moment of awakening is very similar to when you wake up from a dream at night. You feel that you have awakened from one world to another, from one context to a totally different context. On a feeling level, that is the feeling of awakening. This whole separate self that you thought was real, and even the world that you thought was objective, or other, all of a sudden seems as if it’s not as real as you thought.

I’m not saying it is or isn’t a dream; I’m saying that it’s almost like a dream. Upon awakening, the experience is that life is like a dream that’s happening within what you are—within vast, infinite space. Awakening is not experiencing vast, infinite space, feeling spacious or expanded or blissful or whatever. These feelings may be by-products of awakening, but they are not the awakening itself.

Awakening, quite apart from its by-products, is a change of perspective. Everything we thought was real is seen to not be real at all; it’s more like a dream that’s happening within the infinite expanse of emptiness. What is actually real is the infinite expanse of emptiness. It’s the same way that, when you dream at night, your dream does not have reality; it’s your mind, dreaming your dream, which actually has the reality—relatively speaking.

Tami Simon: When you describe your own life story, you say that the rocket ship of your being achieved liftoff at a specific time and date—when you were twenty-five years old. Do you think it is possible that for some people their ship lifted off over a period of a few years—that there wasn’t any specific moment that it happened, but instead it was more like a gradual dawning that that their rocket ship wasn’t on the Earth anymore?

We are empty

Adyashanti: I've seen that, too. I've met people for whom awakening almost happened as if in retrospect, like it snuck up on them. The transition may not have been marked by distinctive, obvious moments. It's almost like they snuck out of the dream or snuck into outer space, and then at some point there was recognition—"Oh, when did that happen?" They can't really point to any distinct moment when there was a change, but they recognize at some point that a real, total change has happened. So it can sneak up on you; it can happen that way, too.

Tami Simon: Not to kill the metaphor here, but is it possible to say that the rocket ship requires a certain kind of fuel, and if so, what kind of fuel?

Adyashanti: I wish I could say what the fuel is. I don't know that it's really possible to say what the fuel is, because it's not limited to something personal. Awakening does not happen just to people who really want it. Awakening does not happen just to people who are sincerely looking for it. It happens to some people completely out of the blue. I've met awakened people who were not on a spiritual path at all. In fact, I've met people who were in denial of spirituality, and then boom—out of nowhere—awakening hits them. We couldn't call such people sincere, and we couldn't say they were pursuing spiritual realization or even had an obvious yearning for it. Of course, the vast majority of people who have an experience of awakening have had some energy, some yearning, to awaken to a deeper sense of reality. That's true, but the problem is, anytime we say "this" is necessary or "that" is necessary, there will always be examples to the contrary. Awakening is a mystery. There is no direct cause and effect, really. It would be nice if there were, but there really isn't a direct cause and effect.

Tami Simon: When you describe the rocket ship, you use the metaphor to talk about nonabiding awakening versus abiding awakening, with the idea that abiding awakening means you are permanently outside of the gravitational field of the dream state, outside of our habitual tendencies to constellate as a separate self. Are you outside of that gravitational field?

Adyashanti: I always hesitate to answer a question like that, but I'm going to try to answer it. I don't feel that I can say, "Yes, I am outside of the gravitational force." It's not really like that. That's where the metaphor breaks down. All of these metaphors, all these ways of explaining things, they're just that—they're metaphors, and they do have certain limitations.

~~I would say that my experience is that I no longer believe the next thought that I have. I'm not capable of actually believing a thought that happens. I have no control over what thoughts appear, but I can't believe that the thought is real or true or significant. And because no thought can be grasped as real, true, or significant, that itself has an experiential impact; it is the experience of freedom.~~

If somebody wanted to call that "being beyond the gravitational force of the dream state," fine, but I am always hesitant about claiming something. I always remind

everybody I talk to that all I know is right now. I don't know about tomorrow. Tomorrow a thought could come by that could catch me, Velcro me, pull me into separation and delusion. I don't know—maybe it will, maybe it won't. I have no way of knowing that. All I know is right now.

That is why I hesitate to say, "Oh yes, I have crossed a certain goal or finish line," because I don't see it that way. It sounds like that when I'm teaching, but that is the limitation of speech. What I really know is that I don't know. What I really know is that there are no guarantees. I don't know what may happen tomorrow, or the next instant, whether I'll be deluded one instant from now. What I do know is that I can never possibly know that.

Tami Simon: Okay, I accept that you don't know about what may happen moving forward in terms of when a Velcro thought may occur, but when was the last time you had a Velcro thought, looking back?

Adyashanti: To be clear, I'm not saying I can't have a Velcro thought or that I don't experience Velcro thoughts. A thought can come that can cause an instant of grasping, that can cause a momentary experience of a certain separateness. I'm not saying that it can't happen or that it doesn't happen. What I'm saying is that when it does happen, the gap between it happening and the seeing through it is very small. I don't know if there's such a state in which such "sticky" thoughts or such moments of grasping would never arise in the human system. It seems to me that to have a human body and mind is to go through those kinds of experiences occasionally. The difference is that at a certain point, the gap between the arising of a sticky thought and its disappearance becomes so narrow that the arising and disappearing is almost simultaneous.

So I wouldn't say that I'm at some state where Velcro thoughts never arise at all. It is just that the gap gets so small that, at a certain point, you almost can't see a gap. I think there are ideas that enlightenment is about getting to some place where ~~nothing~~ uncomfortable ever happens, where no delusory thought will ever walk through your consciousness—those very ideas about enlightenment are delusions; it just doesn't seem to work that way.

Besides, it doesn't really matter. When that gap is so narrow that it can be seen through very quickly, all of a sudden that's part of the freedom, too. We realize it doesn't matter that we've had a thought, because we don't get caught for very long. That's really part of the freedom. I think the rest is selling enlightenment as something it's not. I understand that people can hear what I say and create an image about what abiding realization is. But that's not what I mean to portray. It's more like the gap between the divisive thought and believing in the thought becomes almost nonexistent.

Tami Simon: I am curious what kinds of situations are troublesome and difficult for you. In our conversations, you've shared with me that you can get frustrated at your computer, when, say, your Internet connection or printer is not working. What do you do in those moments? Do you do something to close that gap, or is it just automatic?

Adyashanti: Well, usually the frustration is there, and it's experienced. I experience it, but there's no judging thought about it. That's a real key. And I don't mean that it is dismissed, not paid attention to, but there's no judging thought. In general, it comes, it's experienced, there's no judging thought about it, and then it passes. It's not taken as significant.

* Secondary

There is no secondary thought pattern, "Oh, I shouldn't have gotten frustrated," or "Why did I get frustrated?" or whatever it may be. Thoughts are involved, because it's the thoughts that create the frustration, but they are seen to not be true. Seeing that they're not true dissipates the frustration.

Now, in the past, the process would have been much longer. The inquiry would have been more intense and sustained, and I'd really look at things. But like I said, that gap has narrowed down now, so things happen almost automatically. In a certain sense, it's like being a musician. You practice your scales, and you practice your scales, and you practice your scales, and then at a certain point it's become so internalized that it happens almost without any conscious intention. That to me is what happens with inquiry. At a certain point, it just happens, with little if any conscious intention.

Tami Simon: You often talk about thoughts and feelings like they are two sides of the same coin. Isn't it possible to have feelings that don't have any thoughts associated with them? What about moments of intense awe or an appreciation of beauty, when tears spontaneously come forward? At such moments, isn't it possible that you aren't really thinking anything but that something is just welling up at the feeling level? Or do you believe we are thinking but perhaps at a subtle, subliminal level?

Adyashanti: There is what I would call pure feeling or pure emotion, as anybody who has experienced a great moment of beauty or awe knows. There are pure sensory perceptions, a feeling that comes in that is not created by thought. It happens. However, I would say that the vast majority of emotions that most people experience are duplications of the thinking process; they are thoughts turning into emotion.

But there is pure emotion or pure feeling that bypasses the thinking process. They are how this sensing instrument of ours, this beautiful sensing instrument we call a body, is interacting with the environment, and that is a pure interaction; it's not a virtual interaction.

Tami Simon: All thinking is virtual?

Adyashanti: All thinking is virtual, sure.

Tami Simon: But if there are feelings that are not derived from thinking, then perhaps there are gut experiences that also aren't derived from thinking?

If we look carefully, we will see that the vast majority of emotions that human beings experience are derived from what we are telling ourselves at the moment. That doesn't make those emotions bad or wrong, it's just a fact. Even if we look at something and then comment on it, we can have a positive emotional response. But if we investigate our experience, often we'll realize that what we're actually experiencing is a thought telling us "that's beautiful" or "that's ugly."

How can you tell if an emotion is a pure feeling or is derived from thought? You need to look to see if the emotion comes with a story, if it has images with it. If it does come with images or a story, then you know, "Oh, okay, that's something that's being created; I'm actually experiencing the thoughts in my mind." Which is fine; it is fine to do that. It is just that we can be deluded when we derive our sense of reality from that.

Tami Simon: What about pure perception at the level of the mind? Is there some experience of "awakened mind" in which the mind functions not only as a fabricator of concepts and abstractions but also as a pure sense organ?

Adyashanti: On the level of mind, there is the pure perception of infinity, or what Buddhists call emptiness—the perception of vast, vast, vast, vast vastness. It is being perceived not through the mind in terms of thought, but we could say that section of the body, the mind area, is literally where we are taking in the vastness of infinity, the vastness of space, the pure light of being, the almost blinding light of being. That is being seen on the level of mind, not on the level of thinking. Perceiving in this way is a different capacity than just thinking; it is the mind as a sensing instrument sensing infinity.

Tami Simon: You mentioned that all spiritual paths ultimately bring us to a state of total surrender. But what if the parts of us that don't want to surrender are hidden, quite buried in our psyche? Consciously, we might surrender everything, but some part of us in our unconscious might still be clutching. How do we get those hiding places to come forward? I can imagine hearing your teaching on surrender and thinking, okay, I basically understand. I know what it means to be on my knees. I know what it means to throw myself down on the ground. But what about the parts in me that won't surrender? They're not obvious to me.

Adyashanti: There may be nothing you can do about it. This is the thing that people avoid the most, right? Give me something; give me a teaching; give me some hope. Of course, inside of us there are totally unconscious ways of holding, patterns of holding that we don't have any access to. Maybe you don't have access to it, period. End of story. That's it.

You will have access to it at the exact moment that you are meant to have access to it. We may not like that. People may not like to hear that, but let's look at our lives, not philosophy or teaching or what we choose to tell ourselves, right?

At least in my life, I can certainly look and see that there were moments where I did not have certain capacities yet. They just weren't there. I have no idea what I could have done to bring those capacities forward. At certain points, I couldn't have even heard somebody who told me how to have those capacities.

I had my own teacher tell me certain things literally hundreds of times over the years. And only after ten years did I think, "Oh . . . now I get it. Now I understand. Now it has sunk in." How was I going to force it ten years before? Could I have forced it? It doesn't appear as though I could have.

This may not be the empowering spiritual teaching you are looking for, but everything has its time; everything has its place. Ego is not in control of what's happening. Life is in control of what's happening. To insist that something can empower us, all at once, to dive into ourselves and see anything and everything we need to see to awaken, is working at odds with people's experience.

Everything happens in its time. You're not in control. This isn't something we want to hear, though, is it? It isn't something our mind wants. Mostly we want to hear things that empower our sense of control. And we radically push away anything that does not empower our sense of control.

I say this to people all the time. When you start to accept what you see as true—not what I say, but your experience— that's when everything starts to change.

Many times students come to me and say, "I can't do anything about this, this part of my delusional apparatus, this part of my personality." They'll ask, "What do I do? What do I do?" Often I say, "Well, let's go back. You just told me there's nothing you can do. Is that true? Has anything worked so far?" "No, nothing's worked so far." And I ask, "Can you find anything to do? Can you see anything to do?" And sometimes they'll tell me, "No, honestly, I can't see anything to do." And I'll say, "What would happen if you actually ingested that part of your experience that is telling you there is nothing you can do? What if you took it in instead of trying to push it away?"

Often, when they take this in—not just conceptually, not as a teaching that can be dismissed, but really allowing it into the body—then this realization of what it is like to live without resistance starts to change everything. Sometimes the experiences that we are pushing away contain the most transformative insights we need to have. Who would suspect that seeing that there's nothing, nothing, nothing I can do is going to be transformative? We're not taught that. We're taught to avoid that piece of knowledge at all costs. Even if it's part of your experience, year after year, decade after decade—even if you keep experiencing the same thing over and over—the impulse is to avoid it, to not let it in, to push it away. See what I mean?

We're all junkies. Really, we're all just junkies wanting to be high and free. It's the same dynamic. It's the alcoholic who realizes, "There's nothing I can do," who is on the way to sobering up. As long as that person sitting there is saying, "I can do this. I'm in control. I

can find a way beyond this,” no transformation is going to happen. Bottoming out is nothing more than coming out of denial. There’s nothing I can do, and look where I am. We don’t need to know so much about what to do. We need to have a mirror in front of us so we are able to see what we see. When that alcoholic sees and that drug addict sees that there is nothing they can do, that they are powerless to stop their addiction—only then do they start to see themselves in a clearer light.

There’s a transformation that starts to happen that is not contrived; it is not practiced; it is not technique oriented. To me, spirituality is a willingness to fall flat on your face. That’s why, although my students often put me up on a pedestal and think I’ve figured out something wonderful, I tell them all the time—my path was the path of failure. Everything I tried failed. It doesn’t mean that the trying didn’t play an important role. The trying did play a role. The effort did play a role. The struggle did play a role.

But it played a role because it got me to an end of that role. I danced that dance until it was extinguished. But I failed. I failed at meditating well; I failed at figuring out the truth. Everything I ever used to succeed spiritually failed. But at the moment of failure, that’s when everything opens up.

We know that, right? This isn’t sacred knowledge. Almost everybody knows this; we’ve experienced it in our lives. We’ve seen moments like this. But it’s not something we want to know, because it’s not convenient.

Tami Simon: You suggested that we ask of ourselves, “What do I know for certain?” I would ask that question of you. Is there anything you know for certain?

Adyashanti: Only that I am; that’s it. One thing. So in many senses I’m the dumbest person on the planet. Literally. Everything else, to me, is in a state of flux and uncertainty. Everything else we only dream that we know. I don’t know what should happen. I don’t know if we’re evolving or devolving; I don’t know any of that.

But the thing is, I know that I don’t know. And contrary to what you might think, that knowledge hasn’t disempowered me. I haven’t gone to sit in a cave in the Himalayas or to just sit on the couch and say, “Oh well. There’s nothing for me to do, because I don’t know anything.”

Quite the contrary—life has a part to play through me, and so I play that part. I’m in union with the part life plays through me. The part changes all the time, moment to moment, but that’s what I’m in union with. I’m no longer arguing with life—it gets to play its part through me, and now it gets to play its part with agreement, instead of disagreement.

And it seems that when we’re in the deepest state of agreement, the part life plays through us is very satisfying; it’s literally everything we ever wanted, even though it doesn’t look like anything we ever wanted.

Tami Simon: I loved your teaching on the cul-de-sacs that people can get into after an initial experience of awakening. I am curious if you would comment on a cul-de-sac that I see fairly often, which is when people decide to take on some kind of special mission to save the world after they have an initial awakening experience. Do you see this as a cul-de-sac, a way that the ego has claimed the awakening experience for its own aggrandizement?

Adyashanti: Let me talk about it from my experience. Awakening didn't engender that sense for me. I didn't feel like I needed to go out and save the world, but strangely enough, when my teacher asked me to start teaching, to start sharing the possibility of this realization, what arose in me was a sense of possibility. I saw that awakening was possible for anybody and everybody. There was a certain sense of missionary zeal about it, which can be alluring and empowering. There's something wonderful in that inspiration when it comes from a true place.

There was a lot of energy for it, especially in the first couple of years that I was teaching. I've found that it can be part and parcel of awakening, because one senses that all this suffering is unnecessary; one really can wake up from this. A sense of mission can come from that place.

After a few years of feeling that missionary zeal myself, I noticed it started to ebb. At first it was like I was a new puppy in the house, jumping up and down at your legs all the time, wanting attention and wanting you to do something. The first couple of years of my teaching I felt empowered with what works and what helps people, and I wanted to share it with people. But after two or three years, that energy waned. I started to feel more like an old dog that was curled up at the side of its master's easy chair, lying there and letting the world go by.

At this point in my life, the sense of missionary zeal is pretty much gone. There is no sense that something needs to happen. I see the potential in everybody, but there's no sense of hurry about it.

I see it as a process of maturing. It's a phase that many of us go through. I think the key is—do we go through it? Do we keep going? Or, at some point, does that missionary zeal provide the platform for the ego's reformation? If that starts happening—if the ego uses awakening as a new and improved missionary platform—that can lead to all kinds of distortions.

For example, we might start seeing ourselves as the savior of humanity or our teachings as the greatest teachings ever. As far as I can see, if things go that way, we start to get delusional. Often, when this happens, it's because someone's ego has grasped on to some powerful experience he or she has had. If there's latent energy there, and that energy starts flowing into the ego, it can lead to some of the deepest delusions possible.

We've seen this from time to time in disastrous cult-like behavior. This can happen when there is a lot of energy flowing into the ego and deluding it. Before you know it, you think you are the savior of humanity.

Whereas in truth, none of us is the savior of humanity. The greatest avatar who has ever walked the Earth, if such embodiments even exist, is like a grain of sand on a vast beach. As human beings, we are all just doing our little part. It's the totality; it's the One itself that we are but expressions of. If any of us start to think we are playing a bigger part than we are—if we see ourselves as anything but a small part of an infinite mosaic—it seems to me we're starting to become inflated and deluding ourselves.

Tami Simon: Do you have any suggestions for how we can point out to people that their ego is using their realization as a form of personal territory? I encounter this quite a lot and have difficulty pointing it out in any kind of effective way.

Adyashanti: Traditionally, there were some safeguards used by spiritual traditions to prevent the ego using realization in this way, but if we look back in the history of spirituality, we see the safeguards didn't work that well. Often, people who had a profound realization were part of a bigger community. Even teachers were part of a community of teachers. The idea was that people would keep an eye on each other.

In truth, it never happened like it was supposed to. Teachers can keep an eye on their students, but once somebody breaks out of that role, there's not that much keeping an eye on each other. I mean, we've seen that in almost every tradition. There are people who get inflated or go off on some strange tangent. I do think it's perfectly appropriate that we try, if not to change people, then to reflect back to them—especially if we see somebody really half-cocked. Not that they'll listen!

I wish I had a good antidote to what you are describing. I've mentioned that, as a teacher, when I discover students who are inflated with their own realization, it is the hardest thing for me to get them out of. I think it's one of the hardest things for a spiritual teacher to deal with. And if a spiritual teacher has a difficult time with his or her students, where there is already a certain sense of trust, how much harder is it going to be for the average person to come up to someone and say, "Hey, you know, you may not be as pristine an example of liberation as you think you are."? It can be a really difficult thing to do.

Without making excuses for anybody, we do each have a certain karmic makeup. I have been the type of person, through no choice of my own, who has never been attracted to power. Here I am, a spiritual teacher, which is a role that people give great power to. However, the way I see it, the truth is that I have no power at all except the power that other people grant me. All the power is in the students' hands. And it's good for people to know that. I've always experienced that when people give me too much power or authority, I start to feel like I'm living in a surreal bubble. Inherent in people giving other people power is a projection, right? When somebody gives me too much power, they've

projected that I am something different from them. And I find that a surreal environment to be in. That's why I avoid it as much as I can, because it has a sense of unreality to it.

Other people, quite obviously, are more attracted to power than I am. They find it alluring to be the positive projection of others. It's enticing to them. I couldn't say exactly why; it's just never been comfortable for me, personally.

Tami Simon: At the age of twenty-five, when you experienced what you call your "first awakening," you mentioned that you heard a voice that said, "Keep going, keep going." What is that voice? Would you call it your conscience, or the still, small voice within?

Adyashanti: You can call it either one of those.

Tami Simon: It seems that if we each have that type of inner voice, then that inner voice would keep us from co-opting our realizations into a personal power play. You heard that voice that said your realization was not complete, but does everybody possess an inner voice like that?

Adyashanti: In one sense, I would say yes. In an ultimate sense, we are all the same, so we all have access to the same capacities. At the relative level, however, the question is whether everybody hears their inner voice. Apparently, not everyone does.

What is this inner voice of wisdom? It is what I am pointing to when I talk about sincerity. It is the intelligence within us that keeps us on track, keeps us in alignment.

In one sense, I think almost everybody has experienced this still, small voice. The example I often give is when you are dating some man or some woman and it ends badly. Something inside you says, "Don't do that again." But then we meet someone new, and we don't listen to the voice. We are attracted; this person is sexy, and we just want to be with him or her. In the end, we find that the still, small voice was correct. We shouldn't have kept dating that person. In the end, it all collapses, and in the end, this still, small voice wins.

So this still, small voice is not mystical. It is something that I think a vast majority of people have heard at times. But we're so good at dismissing it. We want that still, small voice to justify itself—to tell us why. One of the good indications that the voice within us is authentic and sincere is that it will never justify itself. If you ask it, "Why?" you'll get silence. If you ask it to explain itself, it won't. The still, small voice doesn't need to do that—and it doesn't.

If you are talking to the ego and you ask, "Why?" it will talk back to you. If you ask the ego, "Does this mean everything will be okay?" it will give you assurances. The still, small voice, though, has an inherent sort of insecurity about it. It offers no guarantees. The voice is a gift. Either we listen or we don't.

Why I listened, and why others don't, I don't know. I couldn't say why. I'm just glad that the voice was there in my case and that I could hear it. It was persistent. And, by the way, I didn't always listen to it. Many, many times I didn't listen to it.

Tami Simon: Is that voice like a guide, a protector, or just part of our mind, part of who we are?

Adyashanti: I think it's all of that. It is a guide. It is a protector. It is the flow of existence. By the way, this intelligent flow of existence doesn't always show up as a voice. It's not always audible. At this point, for me, it's very rarely audible. At other points, it was literally a voice. As I said, during that first realization, the voice said, "This isn't the whole of it. Keep going," and it was an audible experience.

But now, this guiding intelligence appears more as a flow. It is more like sensing the energy currents in life. The voice is also an indicator of the flow. I think it has to become a voice when we can't feel the natural flow of life, the flow to turn left or the flow to turn right, the flow to do this or the flow to do that.

Many of us aren't sensitive enough to feel that, and so the flow appears as a voice. But at this point, for me, it's much more like following a natural flow. As the Taoists would say, follow the flow of the Tao.

So it has different aspects to it. It's a flow. It's a voice. It's a protector voice. It's your counselor. It's your conscience, but not the conscience society taught us. It is a different conscience than that. Because the conscience that society taught us is our superego—and that conscience always contains judgments. This is not the superego. This is something else. This comes from a totally different state of being.

Tami Simon: You've talked about how, early on, you came to the discovery that you couldn't ride the coattails of a teacher, a path, or a tradition, that you were going to have to find your own way, and how important that was.

Adyashanti: That was hugely important for me.

Tami Simon: And you encouraged your students to also find their own way. What is interesting to me is that, at the same time, it seems that many people, including me, feel a connection with you and feel somehow less alone because of knowing you, almost like we are alone but together at the same time. Could you talk about that?

Adyashanti: When I was in my early twenties, and I realized that I needed to find my own way and not rely solely on a tradition or a teacher, an image came to me. It was an image of being out on a space walk with a cord connecting me to a space capsule, and at a certain point, I reached down and cut the connecting cord. I was alone, and I wasn't dependent on anyone or anything. Yet, this didn't mean that I left my teacher; this didn't mean that I left my tradition. I didn't reject anything. It was simply a seeing that

ultimately the responsibility is here; it's in me. Ultimately, no tradition, no teacher, no teaching is going to save me from myself. I realized I can't abdicate that authority.

And, of course, at that moment, it was very frightening. I thought, my God, what if I delude myself? At that moment, I knew that I didn't know much. And yet there I was, determined that everything needed to be verified inside.

Many people have told me that they see themselves as my students and that it is different from studying with other teachers, because I'm not the kind of spiritual teacher who has a personal relationship with my students. I come, I teach, we interact when I teach, but I don't have a retreat center; I don't have an avenue in which we relate in a casual way. It is moment by moment by moment by moment by moment by moment.

This is not the only kind of relationship to have with a teacher, by the way. I think close student-teacher relationships have a great part to play as well. In fact, when my teaching started to get bigger, when it went from small to quite large over the course of several years, there were some people who missed the smallness. The smallness worked for some people—I would teach, we'd have tea or lunch or breakfast afterward, and that worked for certain people. When the teaching got bigger, and by necessity the structure of things changed, for some of those people it no longer worked. They had to go find something that better met their needs, where there was more intimacy.

By the very nature of it, the style in which I teach is one in which people need to at once stand on their own, but also through standing on their own to find a certain intimacy with each other. That's where I meet people, in that place where I see them as whole and capable and having capacities that they may not think they have. And when they stand there and they start to discover their own inner sufficiency, that's where we meet. I don't meet people in their insufficiency, where they don't think they're capable. The more they stand up in themselves the more we find ourselves meeting in an intimate way, a very personal, impersonal way.

There are a lot of influences that come to our aid when we're willing to be on our own—seen and unseen, known and unknown. The point is not to get stuck on the idea that it is all about being alone. That is a particular experience of a moment of aloneness, of facing oneself, of not grasping on to the teacher or the tradition or the teachings—including mine, by the way. All of a sudden, you are left with yourself; that is the aloneness. But when we face that and we are willing to be there, mysteriously we start to find we have lots of company. There are lots of people doing the same thing. The teachings start to be seen in a different way; the teachers that we may study with start to be seen in a different way. A much more mature relationship ensues from that point.

Tami Simon: During what you call your “final awakening,” at the age of thirty-two, you have mentioned in other interviews that part of that experience included seeing your past lives. I realize that this is not something you like to talk about.

Adyashanti: Yes, we know each other well enough that you know that, but it looks like you are going to move forward anyway—good for you.

Tami Simon: The legend, as you know, is that the Buddha, sitting under the Bodhi Tree, saw his past lives flash before him as part of his awakening. I'd like to know what you saw.

Adyashanti: I will try to explain what happened experientially. At the moment of awakening, it was as though I was completely outside who I thought I was. There was a vast, vast, vast emptiness. In that vast emptiness, in that infinite emptiness, there was the smallest, smallest, smallest point of light you could imagine. And that smallest point of light was a thought, just floating out there. And the thought was: "I." And when I turned and looked at the thought, all I had to do was become interested in it, in any way interested, and this little point of light would move closer and closer and closer. It was like moving close to a knothole in a fence—when you get your eye right up to it, you don't see the fence anymore; you see what's on the other side.

So as this little point of "I" came closer, I started to perceive through this point called "me." And I found that in that point called "me" was the whole world. The whole world was contained within that "I," within that little point called "me." There wasn't really an I, but an emptiness that could go into and out of that point, in and out of it, and it's like the whole world could flicker on and off, and on and off, and on and off.

And then I noticed there were all sorts of other points, points, and I could enter each one of those points, and each one of those points was a different world, a different time, and I was a different person, a totally different manifestation in each one of those points. I could go into each one of them and see a totally different dream of self and a totally different world that was being dreamed as well.

For the most part, what I saw was anything that was unresolved about the dream of "me" in a particular lifetime. There were certain confusions, fears, hesitations, and doubts that were unresolved in particular lifetimes. In certain lifetimes, what was unresolved was a feeling of confusion about what happened at the time of death. In one lifetime, I drowned and did not know what was happening, and there was tremendous terror and confusion as the body disappeared into the water.

Seeing this lifetime and the confusion at the moment of death, I immediately knew what I had to do. I had to rectify the confusion and explain to the dream of me that I died, that I fell off a boat and drowned. When I did this, all of a sudden the confusion from that lifetime popped like a bubble, and there was a tremendous sense of freedom. Many past-life dreams appeared and each one of them seemed to focus on something that had been in conflict, something that was unresolved from a different incarnation. I went through each one of them and unhooked the confusion.

Tami Simon: Were you lying on a carpeted floor with your eyes closed or something?

Adyashanti: No, actually, the strangest thing was that I was walking across the living room when all of this happened. I can't tell you how long I was walking. It could have been five seconds—because all of this is outside of time—I don't actually know. I could have been walking across the living room floor for five hours, but I was, literally, just walking across the living room.

And it's not like I stood still; I was walking and it all happened right in the midst of what I was doing. I walked across the living room, I went into the backyard, I was doing something, I don't even remember what I was doing, and simultaneously this whole other thing was happening, too. I know it sounds odd. This didn't happen in a moment of meditation; it was completely mixed in as a part of ordinary life.

As you know, I haven't talked much about this kind of thing. I don't want to talk to a lot of people about past lives, especially the radical nondualists who say that there is nobody who was born, there is nobody who has past lives, there are no incarnations, and so on. Of course, that is all true; it's all a dream, even past lives. When I talk about them at all, I talk about them as past dreams. I dreamed I was this person; I dreamed I was that person.

Personally, I've never tried to gather experiences of past lives and wrap them all up in some sort of metaphysical understanding. I don't have a clear understanding about what a past life is, except that it seems clear to me that it also has the nature of a dream; it doesn't have objective, actual existence. Nonetheless, the experience I had happened. Since it happened, I can't say it didn't happen. But in my own mind, I don't try to figure it all out. All I know is what happened.

Tami Simon: Was there a sense when you looked at each of these dreams that there was some kind of resolution occurring?

Adyashanti: Yes. Not only a resolution there, but also a resolution now. Because it's all one thing. Because anything that was unresolved in one of those dreams was unresolved now. Because it's the same; there's a connection.

One of the reasons I haven't talked much about past lives is that some people who are extraordinarily awake have never seen a past life at all. Being aware of past lives is not a necessity. I'm not a particularly mystical person. There was a relatively short period of time, a few months, when I had these kinds of experiences happen occasionally, and since then, every now and then, but not with any great consistency. So they don't need to happen; it's just that they did happen and it's not uncommon for them to happen for some people. What people usually see, if their experiences are real, is what needs to be seen, what needs to be freed.

As one great Buddhist abbess said to me, "You usually don't have a past life that shows you what a sterling example of enlightenment you were, because enlightenment leaves no trace; it is like a fire that burns clean. There's no karmic imprint it leaves behind." She said if you have any past lives, you're probably going to see what a grade-A jackass you

were—which I loved, and which has corresponded to my experience. I didn't necessarily always see what a grade-A jackass I was, although in some cases, I saw that I was a lot more than a grade-A jackass. Most of the past lives I saw were moments of confusion, moments of unresolved karmic conflict.

Tami Simon: Part of the reason I am bringing up the topic of past lives is that I have heard several people say something like this about you: "Adya must have been a realized being in a past life and that's why he's had such tremendous breakthroughs at such an early age and is able to articulate teachings on awakening in such an original way." What do you think about that comment?

Adyashanti: If you ask me point blank, then yes, I've seen myself doing something similar to what I'm doing in this lifetime many times before. But again, I don't know the whole metaphysics of past lives and how they work and I don't see things happening in terms of linear cause and effect. In fact, my experience of past lives isn't that they are actually past. I call them that because that's how people relate to them, but if I were to say what my real experience is, it's more like simultaneous lives.

It's like if you have a dream at night and in the dream you are a particular person. And in your dream you start to remember, say, all these past lives. Say you remember fifty past lives very intimately, very clearly. "Oh, this happened or that happened." And it seems like it happened in the past. Then you wake up from the dream and you're lying there in your bed and, "Wow, that was an interesting dream. I dreamed that I was somebody who had all of these past life experiences." It may occur to you, "Wait a minute, I was dreaming up those past lives all at once. All of them were being dreamed right now. They didn't have any existence before I dreamed them." That's kind of how I see it.

I don't see them as past because they're all simultaneously occurring, all simultaneously interacting.

Tami Simon: Having seen through the fence hole opening to different dreams, what do you think will happen—and don't say you don't know!—when we die? What do you think that experience will be like?

Adyashanti: And I can't say I don't know? Well now you've really tied my hands, Tami.

My mind doesn't go to what will happen when I die. If I think about death, the only place my mind goes is that death is just the next experience—that's all it is. It's the next experience; it is a different experience than sitting here talking to you, undeniably, but ultimately it's the next experience that consciousness has.

Nothing dies. Spirit doesn't die, but it does have the experience that we call death—the dissolution of a body, the dissolution of a lifespan, of a personality—all that dissolves. And Spirit or consciousness has that experience, just like it has the experience of being born and living and talking to you at this moment.

This moment is Spirit having this experience. If you ask me, "What's death going to be like?" I can't relate to it as this thing we think of as death actually happening the way we think it does. I have nothing in me that relates to death as an actual fact. I relate to death as an experience. Just like the next experience. It will be wonderful to see what that experience is like. But I don't see it with a sense of finality or with any of the common connotations that we think of as death.

Tami Simon: Do you think there's any quality of experience that's available after death that's not available when you are incarnate?

Adyashanti: Waking up is dying. That's what it is. When the awakening happened, I died. Everything disappeared, blanked out. Everything that everybody fears the most is what happened to me. Total blankness. Absolute nonexistence. Nothingness, nothingness, nothingness. At that moment, no past life, no present life—nothing—no consciousness, no birth, no sickness, no nothing. Zero. It's everything that everybody is terrified of. That's what happened to me; that's death.

And it just so happens that death is itself life. We must die in order to truly live. We must experience absolute nonexistence in order to truly exist in a conscious way.

Tami Simon: I've heard people say, "Such and such will become available after you die, but while you're in a human body, you can't know this or that. Once you're not in a body, then there'll be enough freed up for you to know."

Adyashanti: All of us will experience exactly what we believe. If you believe that, that's what you will experience. Remember, there's no such thing as "objective" reality, an objective way that everything must work. It works the way you dream it to work. That's the only way it works. That's the only thing that's happening. So if one believes that, it means that's the dream that consciousness is having through them, but that dream has no more validity than any other dream.

Of course, at the moment of physical death, there is the dropping away of the physical experience. In a sense, it's a forced awakening. When the physical body drops away, the personality structure is going to drop away as well. It's not that you are going to be detached from it; it's just going to be taken away. At that moment, a lot becomes available, because a lot of what you grab hold of is no longer there. You're no longer dreaming the body into existence—it's just not there. So does a lot become possible? Of course.

The same thing is true for some people who are near death. Some of the most amazing experiences I've had have been with human beings who are very close to death. I've come to visit them at their bedside. And those who are ready for it have already let go. Sitting at their bedside, you can feel death approaching and how they have already let go of the body. In a real sense, they've already died, they have already let go, and they already know, some of them, that all is well.

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When you're lucky enough to be in the presence of someone like that, there is an experience of total radiance. It is as if the body has become totally transparent to Spirit, to the inner presence. And the only reason it's become transparent is because the person is no longer holding on to it.

So, clearly, the actual physical moment of death doesn't need to happen for someone to let go, not ultimately.

More from Adyashanti »

Adyashanti (whose name means "primordial peace") dares all seekers of peace and freedom to take the possibility of liberation in this life seriously. He began teaching in 1996, at the request of his Zen teacher with whom he had been studying for fourteen years. Since then, many spiritual seekers have awakened to their true nature while spending time with Adyashanti.

The author of *The End of Your World*, *Emptiness Dancing*, *The Impact of Awakening*, and *My Secret Is Silence*, Adyashanti offers spontaneous and direct nondual teachings that have been compared to those of the early Zen masters and Advaita Vedanta sages. However, Adya says, "If you filter my words through any tradition or '-ism,' you will miss altogether what I am saying. The liberating truth is not static; it is alive. It cannot be put into concepts and be understood by the mind. The truth lies beyond all forms of conceptual fundamentalism. What you are is the beyond—awake and present, here and now already. I am simply helping you to realize that."

A native of Northern California, Adyashanti lives with his wife, Mukti, and teaches extensively in the San Francisco Bay Area, offering satsangs, weekend intensives, and silent retreats. He also travels to teach in other areas of the United States and Canada.

Adyashanti: The gut is just another way in which we sense the world. You hear this when people say, "I have a gut feeling." Sensing with the gut is a certain type of intuitive capacity; it is an instinctual way of knowing. We feel things through that place in the body: our gut is an intuitive sense organ. Of course, we can feel things that are duplications of the mind—fearful thoughts, angry thoughts, conflicting thoughts, contracting thoughts—but the gut also responds as a pure sense organ to what's happening.

When thought isn't constricting who we are, people have these kinds of intuitive experiences. Say you walk up to the edge of a cliff. You look down, and you see a huge expanse. There may be fear when you look down, but if you are sensitive, you might notice another response, which is that your consciousness may actually fill the expanse. When we look at huge expanses, often we breathe in, right? In the breathing in, we're feeling our consciousness open to that environment. We breathe into our lungs, into our heart center, into our gut. Our whole being, our whole body, is in tune with the environment. This kind of opening of the heart—when the lungs go "aah" as consciousness expands— isn't happening because we're thinking. This is happening because consciousness is interacting with the environment. This is what I mean by pure sensation or pure feeling. And yes, it happens through gut sensations as well. It's very powerful and it's very, very beautiful.

It's literally the experience of intimacy. It is our being experiencing itself with an incredible intimacy. I'm not saying it's wrong to comment on it, but as soon as we say something, as soon as we turn to our friend, something changes. For most people, that experience happens for a split second, and then they turn to somebody and say, "Isn't it beautiful?" And that's not a wrong thing to say. I say it to people, too, sometimes. But at that moment, if you're sensitive, you notice that your whole internal environment starts to change, and you start to experience what you just said. Then you are moving into a virtual experience. It's slightly different from that moment of awe, that moment where the entire body is participating in perception.

Tami Simon: It's one thing for someone to have the experience of pure feeling when they are experiencing awe and wonder in nature, but is it possible to have a pure feeling when it comes to an emotion like anger? Do you think it's possible to have a feeling like anger that isn't a duplicated thought?

Pure anger!

Adyashanti: Of course, of course. This idea that enlightenment is about people having beatific, silly little smiles on their faces all the time is simply an illusion. I like to counter that with imagining that we are in a modern-day church, and somebody comes in the back door and blows his lid like Jesus did, kicking over the money changers, yelling at the top of his lungs, "How dare you defile my father's house!" I mean, Jesus was throwing a holy fit, right? He was upset. He wasn't faking it. He was literally upset. And he was expressing his upset.

So can one be upset from a nondivided state? Of course, you can. Every emotion is available to us. To be awake doesn't mean we have fewer emotions available to us.

Emotion is just a way that existence functions through us. There is a divided form of anger and there is an undivided form of anger.

Tami Simon: Well, how would I be able to distinguish that inside myself, if I feel a divided form of anger or undivided anger?

Adyashanti: If you feel divided inside.

Tami Simon: If all of me feels angry, then it's undivided?

Adyashanti: I think we've all had the experience where we feel completely angry, but it still feels divisive, conflicted. There is a kind of anger that is—how can I say it?—a good work. In the Tibetan tradition, for example, they have certain depictions of wrathful deities with flaming swords and fire coming out of their hair and their eyes, looking very angry and fierce and frightening, but there is something in those depictions that is different from when you experience your average, ordinary, conflicted anger. It's something that's hard to describe, but if you look at these depictions, what's being shown is a different kind of anger. It's not an anger that's tearing apart in a negative way; it is an anger that is tearing apart in a positive way. I may not be doing a very good job of expressing this, but what I am trying to communicate is that even the experience of anger can come from a pure place.

Tami Simon: I am particularly interested in exploring this topic, because I am someone who used to experience a pretty narrow range of emotions. As I've been growing as a person I now have available to me this huge, wide range of emotional experience, and it's really interesting, rich, and glorious in a lot of ways. When I hear you teach that most emotional experiences are duplicate images of thoughts, I want to really understand which emotional experiences are derivative, based on concepts, and which are pure. And how do I know the difference?

Adyashanti: Please don't misunderstand me. I'm not saying that virtual emotions are something that shouldn't happen or are somehow wrong or somehow secondary. For example, I can think about my wife, Mukti. I can envision her in my mind, and I can feel an incredible, wonderful upswelling of love. I know that that emotional experience is virtual. I know I'm making it up in my mind; I know I'm making it up literally in thought. That doesn't make it wrong. But if I were to equate that emotional experience of love with real love, then I would be living an illusion, perhaps a heavenly illusion, but an illusion nonetheless.

I can create that kind of image in my mind and at times I do that; her image or thoughts about her float through my mind and there is a wonderful upswelling in the heart. So the first thing is to understand that just because an emotional experience is being derived from the mind, that doesn't make it bad or something one shouldn't experience.

